

Why I Never Stopped Courting



I don't think love begins the day two people decide to be together.

I think that's simply the day the real work starts.



People often treat courtship like an entrance exam.

You study.

You prepare.

You give your best.

Then one day someone finally says,

"Yes."

Somewhere after that...

many people stop.

As though the destination had finally been reached.

I've never understood that.



To me...

courtship was never supposed to end.

Not because I enjoy grand romantic gestures.

Honestly, I'm not very good at those.

I simply like making the person I love smile.

Again.

Tomorrow.

The day after that.

Not because I have to.

Because I get to.



I've always believed that love lives inside ordinary repetition.

Making coffee for someone.

Remembering how they like their food.

Sending a random photo because it reminded you of them.

Saving the last piece of chicken.

Walking a little slower because they're tired.

Asking,

"Kumain ka na ba?"

Those things rarely appear in movies.

Yet I think that's where love spends most of its life.



I never wanted someone to fall in love with me only once.

I wanted the chance to earn that feeling again tomorrow.

Not because love should constantly be tested.

Because people constantly change.

The person beside you today won't be exactly the same person next year.

Or ten years from now.

Why should our love stop growing while we continue to?



Sometimes people ask what romance means.

I don't think romance is flowers.

Or expensive dinners.

Or anniversaries.

Those things are beautiful.

But romance, to me, is attention.

It's remembering.

Noticing.

Learning someone so deeply that loving them becomes second nature.

Not automatic.

Intentional.



There will always be seasons.

Days when work is exhausting.

Days when life becomes heavy.

Days when neither of us feels particularly interesting.

I think those are the days that matter most.

Because it's easy to love someone when everything is exciting.

It's ordinary Tuesdays that reveal whether love has quietly become home.



Maybe that's why I've never liked the phrase,

"The honeymoon phase is over."

As though wonder has an expiration date.

I hope mine never does.

I hope I never stop looking across the room and thinking,

"There you are."

Even after years.

Even after wrinkles.

Even after ordinary becomes familiar.

Especially then.



Love doesn't become smaller because it's repeated.

It becomes deeper.

The first "I love you" is unforgettable.

The thousandth one should still mean something.

Not because the words changed.

Because the people saying them did.



If someday I'm lucky enough to grow old beside someone...

I don't want her to remember only how I loved her in the beginning.

I hope she remembers that I kept trying.

That even after years together...

I still wanted to make her laugh.

Still wanted to surprise her.

Still wanted to know who she was becoming.

Because I was still becoming too.



Maybe that's all courtship really is.

Refusing to believe that love has already reached its best chapter.

Believing tomorrow deserves another page.

Another conversation.

Another smile.

Another chance to choose each other.



I don't want to spend my life trying to make someone fall in love with me once.

I'd rather spend it giving her reasons to stay in love...

every ordinary day after.



— Ralph.

